dashing fashion, jumped out of the cockpit'. The girls were suitably impressed, and the foursome drove off for a great evening.

Ratan had the pluck to do what only the more experienced flyers would dare to, says Adrian Bewley, Ratan's contemporary at Cornell. Bewley, who went on to fly for United Airlines for thirty-three years, talks about an instance in 1959 when the twenty-one-year-old Ratan flew into Idlewild Airport to meet his father for lunch in New York, and then flew back to Ithaca. Allen Hayes tried to talk Ratan out of making the flight to Idlewild as it was a very busy airport and the air traffic controllers spoke 'very rapidly' making it difficult to comprehend their instructions. Ratan insisted, and Hayes finally relented on the condition that Ratan would take Bewley along. Ratan flew for four hours and four hundred miles on the trip. He not only piloted the aircraft remarkably well but also tightly parked his single-engine plane beside the international planes at the bay before he walked into the airport to have lunch with his father.

The Fateful Decision

In January 1962, Ratan completed his five-year course in architecture. He was awarded the BSc degree in Architecture with Structural Engineering from Cornell University. He had also done one year at the Cornell Graduate School of Business Administration.

Life at Cornell was extremely rewarding for Ratan. It moulded many aspects of his life and laid the foundation of the qualities that have distinguished him. Commenting on how Cornell transformed his life, Ratan said: 'I do really believe that it's probably the best investment that my father ever made, in allowing me to be here [at Cornell].'

It was now time for him to return to India. Before he left, the gentleman Ratan had an earnest desire to say goodbye to and thank all the people he had become close to in the course of his stay in the US. He first called on his surrogate parents, Ed and Sylvia Vinnicombe, and spent a week with them. It was then that Ratan made the fateful decision to write to Archibald Quincy Jones, the architect from California famous for his modernist style and urban planning, and the outside expert who had evaluated his fifth-year thesis. He followed the letter up with a call.

During their conversation, Jones who had been impressed with Ratan's work, invited him to meet him if he happened to visit Los Angeles. Ratan